



Ollscoil Chathair
Bhaile Átha Cliath
Dublin City University

**School of Computing
RESEARCH ETHICS COMMITTEE**

**APPLICATION FORM FOR ETHICAL REVIEW OF A
RESEARCH PROJECT INVOLVING HUMAN PARTICIPANTS
WHICH IS IN THE CATEGORY OF NOTIFICATION ONLY**

There are 3 generally accepted levels of ethical review for projects carried out in a University or similar setting. These are notification only, expedited and full committee.

This notification only level of review is to approve relatively low-risk research involving human participants, primarily using social science methodologies in which any personal information collected is not of a sensitive nature. The School of Computing Research Ethics Committee has been delegated responsibility by the University to approve ethics submissions from undergraduate and taught Masters projects only, which are in the category of notification only.

Examples of projects in this category include:

- Anonymous surveys in which the topic itself is not likely to elicit significant difficulties for the participants, such as: anonymous internet surveys (e.g. Survey Monkey), street questioning.
- Observation (without audio or visual recording) of public settings where privacy would not normally be expected, such as observing people on streets or at sports events.
- Research carrying no risks beyond those of everyday life (as experienced by the intended participant population), such as asking people's opinions about products or services; asking students about educational experiences; monitoring the impact of daily activities.
- Interviews with public figures, professionals or others in their professional capacity regarding their professional activities.
- Analysis of data (e.g. health records) which have had all identifying information removed by the data holder and been provided to the researcher in accordance with data protection legislation.
- Collection of biological samples which are anonymised and do not require invasive techniques (e.g. hair, nails).

If your project is using data from a public repository like Kaggle or is not generating or using any form of personal data then you do not need research ethics approval, you do not need to complete and to submit this form and your project supervisor should indicate this on the project dashboard.

If your project involves collecting or processing [personal data which is of a personal nature](#), you must first complete the DCU online Data Protection training course and review the "[Data Protection – Key Points for DCU Researchers](#)" guidance from the Data Protection Unit to assist you in meeting your legal obligations under GDPR and associated Irish law.

Once you have completed this form (if you need to) you should save it as a PDF file, not WORD, and upload it to the your project dashboard before you start gathering data. It will then be read and assessed by two members of the committee and once two members of the committee approve your submission you will be automatically notified by email and your project can start data gathering.

There are strict deadlines for submitting this form for each class group, undergraduate and taught Masters by which your submission must be made and you will be informed of these deadlines by your course board chair or project co-ordinator. If you do not submit by these deadlines then the research ethics committee is not obliged to approve your submission and when that happens and your project is assessed and graded at the end of the year, you will be awarded 0 for that component of your project.

SECTION 1 – GENERAL DETAILS**1.1 Project Title**

CA400 Final Year Project - ForkNFind

1.2 Applicant Details

Name	Student or Supervisor	E-mail
Eoin Daly	Student	eoin.daly54@mail.dcu.ie
Thomas Hazekamp	Student	thomas.hazekamp2@mail.dcu.ie
Brian Davis	Supervisor	brian.davis@dcu.ie

Other Investigators: *Including any external to DCU*

Name	School/Unit/External Institution	E-mail

1.3 Key Project Dates

Proposed start date for data collection	Proposed end date for data collection	Proposed project completion date
1/4/2024	14/4/2024	21/4/2024

1.4 Please indicate which academic award

Undergraduate ☒	Taught Masters ☐
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1.5 Please confirm the location(s) where the research will be carried out

If research will be carried out abroad, you will need to address the ethical challenges raised by this in Section 3 of your application - consult the Conducting Research Abroad document in the Ethics Resources and Guidelines section of the [DCU Research Ethics webpage](#)).

Ireland

1.6 Please state what additional permissions may be required to access participants.

Specify from whom the permission is required (e.g. a school Board of Management), and when their written approval will be obtained

None

SECTION 2 – PROJECT DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

Research Overview - Please respect the indicated word counts in the following sections and explain all acronyms in full text the first time they appear.

2.1 Provide a brief description of the research (max 250 words):

Please use lay language, include the scientific/theoretical background of study and a justification as to why this research project should proceed in that context

Our project is a mobile application that allows users to search restaurants, input reviews for restaurants and get recommendations of restaurants that they would likely rate positively or visit. For testing the applications features and the overall UI we want to perform user testing to get general feedback about the overall software experience in hopes of being able to improve the application.

2.2 Please state the aims and objectives of the project (max 200 words)

The aim of the project is to develop an easy to use mobile application that can be used by all age groups. The mobile application, using machine learning, will be able to give relevant recommendations to users to give them the ability to find and discover restaurants in their nearby area that they would be interested in visiting.

2.3 Please confirm your methods of data collection:

Tick all relevant check boxes and provide details for each one, including any devices used to collect data, and whether the data will be anonymous, potentially identifiable or identifiable at point of collection

Method	Describe briefly
☐ Interviews or focus groups	
☐ Surveys/questionnaires	We will be asking users to fill out a google form, the data will be anonymous, this will be done by using the “do not collect email” option allowing users to complete the questionnaire without having their answers be linked to an email.
☐ Audio/video recordings	
☐ Public observations	
☐ Persons in public office	
☐ Using existing data (incl. secondary data)	
☐ Using human derived material (biological samples)	
☐ Standard tests (educational/personality etc.)	
☐ Standard educational practices	
☐ Other (please specify)	

2.4 Please confirm who the participants on this study will be, including group size and composition:

Include associated demographic characteristics, and state how your proposed sample size was determined (e.g. power analysis)

The participants will be family members, friends and there will be a max amount of 10-20 people. We think this number of people will share enough detail to help with our project.

2.5 Please outline your recruitment process, including where you are sourcing participants from and your criteria for inclusion/exclusion:

Where gatekeepers are involved, outline the procedures relating to their involvement

We will be contacting the people involved in our questionnaire through in-person contact and email/online messaging systems in our personal/social network (contact lists)

We only store emails from personal contact lists for the purposes of sending an anonymous survey form. The emails will be stored on secure DCU Google Drive and will be deleted after the project is completed.

The survey is a google conform which contains the anonymous consent form as well the ForKNFind questionnaire (See Pages X). The settings on Google will not store the emails(gmail) of the receipt (Do Not Collect Email Option)

2.6 Addressing participant vulnerability – if your participants fall into any of the following categories, please check the relevant tick box/boxes and state below what special arrangements will be made to protect them:

If your participants are not in any of these categories, tick N/A

☒ N/A
☐ Children under 18 years of age
☐ Persons in unequal relationships with the researcher (e.g. lecturer-student, therapist-client, employer-employee)
☐ People with a recognised or diagnosed intellectual, physical or mental impairment
☐ People confined to institutions (e.g. prisoners, residents in 24 hr nursing facilities)
☐ People who have undergone traumatic or adverse emotional events
☐ People with diminished cognitive ability
☐ Marginalised sections of society
☐ Other (please specify)

Special arrangements:

2.7 Involvement of children under 18 years of age – if your participants are in this category, please confirm compliance with the following:

If your participants are not in this category, tick N/A

☒ N/A

☐ We confirm that we have read and agree to act in accordance with the DCU Child Protection policy and procedures (*as per the [DCU Child Protection Unit webpage](#)*)

☐ We confirm that we have put in place safeguards for the children participating in the research

☐ We confirm that we have supports in place for children who may disclose current or historical abuse (whether or not this is the focus of the research)

☐ We confirm that all requirements will be met prior to commencing the research (*e.g. TUSLA Children First Training completed, Garda Vetting in place*)

2.8 Please confirm how the results of the research will be disseminated:

Include a statement on whether the participants will be provided with any information as to the findings or outcomes of the project

The results of the testing will be kept between Thomas Hazekamp and Eoin Daly. Participants will not be informed of the overall findings of the testing, as the results will be used to improve the functionality and the UI of the mobile application. It is not necessary to inform participants.

SECTION 3 – ETHICAL ISSUES AND RISK MANAGEMENT

3.1 Please identify all issues including ethical issues which may arise in the course of this research. What are the potential risks to participants, and how will those risks be addressed or minimised?

Potential risks can be physical, psychological, social, legal, etc. Please include details of any additional support being provided for participants during/after the study

The overall level of risk to participants is low. We will be providing participants with anonymous test accounts to access the mobile application as this will remove the participants from having to input any personal information of theirs to the mobile application. As the only personal information needed is when creating an account, by not giving the participants the option to do this it removes any risk.

3.2 Please identify the potential benefits (direct and/or indirect) to those participating in this research:

Potential benefits should outweigh the potential risks to participants

Benefits for participants is that they will be recommended restaurants that they would have perhaps been interested in visiting.

3.3 Please describe what measures/protocols you have put in place in the event that there are any unexpected outcomes or adverse effects to participants arising from involvement in the research:

Not applicable

3.4 Do you intend to provide payment or incentives to participants?

Yes ☐

No ☒

If Yes, please consult the REC Guidelines on the Use of Compensation and Incentives (in the Ethics Resources and Guidelines section of the [DCU Research Ethics webpage](#)) before providing additional details below

3.5 Does this research raise any potential risks for the researchers themselves?

Please consider the location/environment where the research is being conducted, exposure to distressing data content etc.

Yes ☐

No ☒

If Yes, please describe further and explain what risk management procedures will be put in place to minimise these risks to researchers:

3.6 Does this research raise any potential conflict of interest?

Please consider any potential real or perceived conflicts of interest that might influence the integrity of the research, or give rise to bias in conducting and reporting the research, or affecting publication (consult the [DCU Conflict of Interest Policy](#) for assistance)

Yes ☐	No ☒
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If Yes, please identify and explain the steps being taken to address that conflict:

3.7 Please describe how the conduct of the research will be monitored:

Regular oversight by the PI is required to ensure the project conforms to the procedures set out in this application (especially where several people are involved in carrying out the research procedures)

The principal investigator (supervisor) will have access to all documentation about the testing, i.e. google form, results from the testing and the ability to check we are adhering to the guidelines.

SECTION 4 – CONFIDENTIALITY AND DATA MANAGEMENT

4.1 Considering your previous response in section 2.3 of the form on data collection, please confirm whether you are collecting or processing personal data in this research project:

Personal data is any information about a living person, where that person is either identified, or could be identified from the data itself, or when it is combined with other data. This includes paper based, electronic and biological samples data. If your data is fully and completely anonymous, it is not personal data.

Yes ☒	No ☐
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If Yes, please confirm your compliance with the following by ticking the checkboxes:

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|--|
| ☒ | We confirm that we have completed the DCU Data Protection training module on Loop. |
| ☒ | We confirm that we have read the “Data Protection – Key Points for DCU Researchers” guidance on the DCU Data Protection Unit (DPU) website and agree to protect and manage our data in accordance with same. |
| ☒ | We have assessed the degree of risk inherent in the personal data being used in the research project, and confirm that all DPU GDPR requirements have been met prior to submitting this application (e.g. completion of Data Protection questionnaire, confirmation that any survey tool being used is GDPR compliant, that required Data Processing or Sharing Agreements will be in place, etc.) |

4.2 Data access – please confirm whether access to participant data is confined to the investigators named on this application:

Yes ☒	No ☐
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If No, please name who the other individuals are and why they need access. Any proposed transfer of data (including outside of the EU) should be detailed here.

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4.3 Data storage – please confirm compliance with the following:

- | | |
|--------------------------|--|
| ☐ | Data collected on mobile devices will be protected with a strong password/passphrase at a minimum, and/or encrypted if the device supports it |
| ☐ | Data will be removed from mobile devices as soon as is practicable and stored in a secured location in DCU (on server or institutional Google Drive) |
| ☐ | Paper based data will be held securely in locked cabinets in DCU, with access restricted to the named researchers |

Specific arrangements in relation to biological samples should be stated here:

Any exemptions to the above compliance statements should be justified here:

4.4 Please confirm who will be responsible for the secure storage of data generated by the research:

Name the relevant DCU investigator/s

Brian Davis

4.5 Please confirm how long the data will be held for:

For personal data, consult section 15: Retention of Personal Data in the [“Data Protection – Key Points for DCU Researchers”](#) guidance on the DCU Data Protection Unit (DPU) website

The data collected will be destroyed after the Progression and Awards board for the current academic year, and then it will be deleted from the google drive as the project once the project is completed

4.6 Please confirm what will happen to the data collected at the end of the study:

Please tick the relevant checkbox and complete the associated follow-up section for that category

Archived ☐	Destroyed ☒	Other ☐
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4.6.1 Archived data

Please provide the following details:

Name the DCU staff member responsible for archival and future use of data	
Confirm whether the data will be made available to other researchers, and if so, how?	
Confirm <u>how</u> the data will be prepared for archive (e.g. will datasets be anonymised)	
Confirm <u>where</u> the data will be archived and who will be allowed to access it	

4.6.2 Destroyed data

Please provide the following details – Note: for student projects, the supervisor must take responsibility for data destruction if there is no guarantee the student will have access to the data at the time of destruction

Please justify why the data will be destroyed	So it cannot be used for unauthorised purposes
Name the DCU researcher responsible for destruction of data	Thomas Hazekamp
Confirm when the data will be destroyed (specify date)	25/05/2024
Confirm compliance with the following destruction methods (tick relevant boxes)	☒ Electronic data will be overwritten/securely deleted ☐ Paper based data will be confidentially shredded ☐ Medical samples will be disposed in accordance with the relevant DCU approved SOP

4.6.2 Other - Please explain what will happen to the data if not being archived or destroyed:

NA - (email addresses) data will be destroyed after the project is completed and exam results are published

SECTION 5 – PARTICIPANT INFORMATION AND INFORMED CONSENT PROCEDURES

In addition to completing this form you are required to attach, within the single PDF that you submit, a copy of (1) the Participation Information Sheet which you share with your participants and (2) a copy of the Informed Consent Form which your participants sign.

5.1 Please confirm that the following items have been addressed in your Participant Information Sheet which should be shared with all participants whether it involves online or in-person data gathering:

The items below should be used as headings in your information sheet. Note the language used under each item must reflect the participant age group and corresponding comprehension level– if your participants have different comprehension levels (e.g. both adult and child participants) then separate sheets must be prepared for each set. Templates are available via the [REC Forms - Applications, Templates and Amendments section](#) of the Research Ethics website.

Checklist – tick the relevant check box for each item	Yes	No
Introductory Statement (Researcher names and titles, school, title of the research study)	☒	☐
What is this research about?	☒	☐
Why is this research being conducted?	☒	☐
Why have you been invited to take part?	☒	☐
What will happen if you decide to take part in this research study?	☒	☐
How will your data be used?	☒	☐
How will your privacy be protected (including any legal limits to confidentiality)?	☒	☐
What are the benefits of taking part in this research study?	☒	☐
What are the risks of taking part in this research study?	☒	☐
Can you change your mind at any stage and withdraw from this study?	☒	☐
How will you find out what happens with this project?	☒	☐
Contact details for further information	☒	☐

If you marked any item as No, please explain and justify why:

5.2 Informed Consent Procedures – please confirm whether written consent is to be obtained:

Please tick the relevant checkbox

Yes ☒

No ☐

If Yes, describe the procedures by which written consent will be obtained. If you are involving child participants, you will also need to obtain their written assent. Templates are available via the [REC Forms - Applications, Templates and Amendments section](#) of the Research Ethics website.

Individual participants will check the relevant boxes stating they agree to participate. These boxes are in the google form, and serve as the written agreement to take part in the survey. Participants will not be able to complete the google form without giving their consent.

If No, describe the procedures regarding how consent/assent will be obtained:

If you are gathering data from an online process such as Google Form or SurveyMonkey then you should use a page such as the one below, to capture participants' informed consent and your data gathering should not proceed until participants have completed this form with the appropriate answers.

ForkNFind forms

This form contains a consent form and a questionnaire

thomas.hazekamp2@mail.dcu.ie [Switch accounts](#)



Not shared

* Indicates required question

I have read and understood the Plain Language Statement? *

☐

Yes

☐

No

I understand the information provided? *

☐

Yes

☐

No

I understand the Data Protection Information? *

☐

Yes

☐

No

I have had the opportunity to ask questions and discuss this study?

☐ Yes

☐ No

I have received answers to all my questions? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

I understand I may withdraw from the Research Study at any point? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

I have read and understand the arrangements to be made to protect confidentiality of data, including that confidentiality of information provided is subject to legal limitations? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

I consent to the participation of this research study? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

ForkNFind Questionnaire



Please answer as many questions as possible, the answers will greatly help our app improvement.

How often would you go out to eat (outside your home)?

- ☐ Once a month
- ☐ Twice a month
- ☐ Four times a month
- ☐ More than 6 times a month

Do you think the mobile app was easy to understand?

- | | | | | | | |
|------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|--------------|
| | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | |
| Not at all | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | Very much so |



Do you think the mobile app was easy to navigate?

- | | | | | | | |
|------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|--------------|
| | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | |
| Not at all | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | Very much so |

How often would you use this application in any given month when going out for food?

- ☐ Never
- ☐ Occasionally
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Always

Were you able to receive a restaurant recommendation?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Do you think the recommendation was accurate?

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Somewhat

Were you able to create an account?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Were you able to login?

☐ Yes

☐ No

...

Were you able to log out?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Were you able to leave a review?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Would you suggest a friend to use this app?

☐ Yes

☐ No

...

Are there any must have features you think we missed? If yes, could you please describe them?

Long-answer text

Please share with us any bug/inconsistencies you found while viewing the app.

Long-answer text

Final feedback about the mobile app

Long-answer text

SECTION 6 – SUBMISSION CHECKLIST AND RESEARCHER DECLARATION

6.1 Please confirm all required supplementary documentation to be included in this application within Section 7:

Checklist – tick the relevant check box for each item	Yes	N/A
Participant Information Sheet/s	☒	
Informed Consent Form/s (Anonymous consent form)	☒	☐
Informed Assent Form/s	☐	☒
Recruitment Advertisement	☐	☒
Questionnaire/Survey	☒	☐
Interview/Focus Group Questions	☐	☒
Debriefing Material	☐	☒
Bibliography	☐	☒
Approval from another Research Ethics Committee	☐	☒
Evidence of other external approvals (e.g. Board of Management letter)	☐	☒
Evidence of internal approvals (e.g. BSC approval review letter)	☐	☒
Other – provide details here:	☐	☒

6.2 Signed Declaration

By submitting this form, the applicant (and supervisor) agree to the following:

The information contained herein is, to the best of my knowledge and belief, accurate. I have read the University's current research ethics guidelines, and accept responsibility for the conduct of the procedures set out in the attached application in accordance with the form guidelines, the [REC guidance and resources](#), the University's [Conflict of Interest Policy](#), its [Code of Good Research Practice](#) and any other condition laid down by the Dublin City University Research Ethics Committee. I have attempted to identify all risks related to the research that may arise in conducting this research and acknowledge my obligations and the rights of the participants.

I also acknowledge my requirement to be informed as to other duties and legal obligations applying to my research, and to comply with these duties and obligations – this includes being informed about DCU Data Protection guidelines for researchers, DCU Child Protection policy and procedures (where relevant) and DCU Insurance requirements.

I and my co-investigators and/or supporting staff have the appropriate qualifications, experience and facilities to conduct the research set out in the attached application and to deal with any emergencies and contingencies related to the research that may arise. Research will not commence until required consents and approvals are in place.

Electronic Signature(s):

Supervisor: Brian Davis

Print Name here: Brian Davis

Date: 2/2/2024

Student(s) signature(s): Thomas Hazekamp, Eoin Daly

Print Name(s) here: Thomas Hazekamp, Eoin Daly

Date: 2/2/2024

SECTION 7 – SUPPLEMENTARY DOCUMENTATION

Please attach all required documentation as confirmed by you in the previous section. The application should then be saved as one file in PDF format before submission via the project dashboard.

Participation Information Sheet

A Participant Information Sheet should use language that reflects the participant age group and corresponding comprehension level. It should cover the following items, retained as headings in the sheet (they are for the participant to read and are therefore phrased accordingly). The information in italics is to prompt the research team to provide the appropriate detail under each heading. Please include additional sections if necessary for your research

Introductory Statement

Researcher Names: Thomas Hazekamp, Eoin Daly
DCU School: Faculty of Engineering and Computing
Title: Final Year Project - ForkNFind

What is this research about?

This research is about gathering feedback for our application ForkNFind, which is a mobile application allowing users to search restaurants, input reviews for restaurants and get recommendations of restaurants that it is believed they would rate positively. Participants will be asked to perform user testing of the application by testing the functionality and UI. They will then have the ability to provide feedback of the overall software experience, allowing us to improve the project.

Why is this research being conducted?

This research is being conducted to create a software product and gain specific feedback on possible improvements and additions.

Why have you been invited to take part?

I have been invited to participate in this research as I provide a diverse range of thoughts and ideas.

What will happen if you decide to take part in this research study?

You will be provided with a QR code which will allow you to use the mobile application, you will be provided with a dummy account to test and view all mobile features. You will be asked to provide feedback and complete an anonymous questionnaire with an anonymous consent form.

Data Protection/ Privacy Notice (Personal Data - GDPR Compliance)

- Data controller: DCU
- The identity of the DCU Data Protection Officer: Mr. Martin Ward (data.protection@dcu.ie Ph: 7005118 / 7008257)
- Data processing: The purpose of data collected during testing is to get external opinions on the UI of our application and the functionality of the application. This will be used to further improve our website design and functionality.
- Data categories: The emails used to contact the participants will be saved and their personal opinions of users will be collected but will be anonymised through the use of google forms.
- Data processor: Google Cloud Service
- Data will not be shared with any external, Non-DCU parties
- The retention period: Data will be deleted the day after the progression and awards board for the current academic year.
- The right of the individual to lodge a complaint with the [Irish Data Protection Commission](https://www.dataprotection.ie/).
- The user can request at any time to remove their personal contact email from the secure DCU servers.
- The collected information will not be used for any other research project outside of this project.

How will your data be used?

The data collected from the anonymous survey will be used to gain feedback about the user friendliness and functionality of the application so as to improve the user experience.

How will your privacy be protected (including any legal limits to confidentiality)?

Participants will not be expected to provide any private information about themselves. You will be given access to artificial accounts which will allow you to test the application without inputting personal information. The online questionnaire and consent forms are fully anonymous. The email used to contact will be stored in secure DCU servers and will be deleted once the project is complete.

Please note that confidentiality of information can only be protected within the limitations of the law - i.e., it is possible for data to be subject to subpoena, freedom of information claim or mandated reporting by some professions.

What are the benefits of taking part in this research study?

The main benefit gained from participating in this study will be gaining a new recommendation on restaurants to visit.

What are the risks of taking part in this study?

There is no risks in taking part in this study

Can you change your mind at any stage and withdraw from this study?

Participants are allowed to withdraw from the study at any point

How will you find out what happens with this project?

Participants will not find out what happens to this project.

Contact details for further information:

Eoin Daly, eoin.daly54@mail.dcu.ie

Thomas Hazekamp, thomas.hazekamp2@mail.dcu.ie

If participants have concerns about this study and wish to contact an independent person, please contact: The Secretary, Dublin City University Research Ethics Committee, c/o Research and Innovation Support, Dublin City University, Dublin 9. Tel 01-7008000, e-mail rec@dcu.ie